suspended.[49] Thus, triggering violence in Rakhine might present an ideal opportunity for the military to retain power. If numerous Rohingyas die or flee as a result, that, to the military, would be a price well worth paying.

This brings us back to the specific dynamics within Rakhine.

2015 elections: dynamics in Rakhine

As noted earlier in this book, the political dynamics in Rakhine are different from the rest of the country. In part, there is a greater degree of direct military rule, and the notional opposition to the USDP is not the NLD but regional and ethnically-based parties. The Rakhine confessional parties have regularly divided. In 1988 they were the Arakan League for Democracy (ALD) but by 2008 most members had left to form the Rakhine Nationalities Development Party (RNDP). The name was subsequently changed to the Rakhine National Party (RNP) and is currently the Arakan National Party[50] (ANP). These transitions have been complicated as at each stage some members have opted to retain the old name, reflecting different geographical and economic power bases within Rakhine. In particular, a party calling itself the RNDP contested the 2015 elections—this effectively split the ethnic Rakhine vote, significantly reducing the parliamentary representation of the Rakhine ethnic parties.

The ANP is proving to have volatile internal politics, as leaders of the previous incarnations of the party all push for power and influence.[51] Its predecessor, the RNDP, was heavily implicated in the 2012 and 2013 massacres[52] and regularly called for the expulsion of the Rohingyas (a platform the original ALD promoted during the 1990 elections). The stated platform of the ANP is to ‘represent the interests of Rakhine people in Rakhine (Arakan) state and the Yangon region’.[53] In other words, it is a self-declared ethno-centric party.

At the time of the 2012 violence, the ANP demanded that ‘Bengalis must be segregated and settled in separate, temporary places so that the Rakhines and Bengalis are not able to mix together in villages and towns in Rakhine state’.[54]

The ANP has produced electoral leaflets with the slogan ‘Love your nationality, keep pure blood, be Rakhine and vote ANP’.[55] The elimination of the Rohingyas from the electoral roll potentially increased the number of